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On a busy day, about half a million people pass through New York's Times Square, a big tourist attraction known for its innovative advertising and digital billboards. On Sunday, October 8, a campaign titled 'Be More Milk' went live there. Targeted at youngsters, this 15-second message has been playing out 20 times an hour and 480 times daily. What's cool is that it is an initiative run by Amul, one of India's most well-known brands. The Amul advertisement is at the Nasdaq MarketSite.

It will run for four weeks and is expected to strengthen the base of the Indian dairy major's journey into foreign markets, although it pushes the cause of milk more than of Amul. The dairy major wants to go beyond the Indian diaspora.

And it has the muscle: for FY23, Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation (GCMMF), which

owns the Amul brand name, reported a turnover of ₹55,070 crore, an increase of over 18 per cent on the previous year. The target for FY26 is ₹1 lakh crore. The group turnover, or the unduplicated sales (this includes those of member unions) of all products under the brand Amul, exceeded ₹72,000 crore last financial year.

Milk and milk products still account for 96 per cent of GCMMF's revenue. But it wants to change this by aiming for scale in new businesses that fit nicely into the Amul supply chain and its closeness to farmers. For one, the co-operative behemoth is hungry for organic food.

SPOTTING THE TREND

There is a smile on Jayen S. Mehta's face as he pops in a *gud kaju katli*, a sweet made of jaggery, cashew and milk. "It is quite addictive," says the 54-year-old Managing Director of Amul. Mehta joined in 1991 as a freshly minted graduate of the Institute of Rural Management Anand (Irma) and succeeded R.S. Sodhi this January.

Amul's decision to move beyond dairy into foods has been interesting and perplexing. The two are very different businesses with unique challenges. India is the world's top producer of milk, which is also its largest agricultural product. "At ₹10 lakh crore, milk is larger than wheat, paddy, and oilseeds put together," he says.

Amul is a big brand, and the trust it enjoys "is our currency". If the farmer-owned co-operative can churn a perishable product such as milk into a portfolio of products, it reckons it can do better with farm produce. "We can do it with wheat and potatoes, for instance. Making a frozen potato snack is logical, but core agriculture was never a part of our thinking," explains Mehta.

Everything changed when the management began



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"Amul's marketing has been down-to-earth, simple and focussed on the product. They have never used celebrities, and the quality value has spoken for itself"